

New Puppy Essentials Checklist

Your first 30 days with a new puppy — printable guide

BEFORE YOU BRING YOUR PUPPY HOME

FOOD & WATER

- ☐ Puppy food (complete & balanced for growth)
- ☐ Stainless steel food & water bowls
- ☐ Soft training treats
- ☐ Slow feeder (if puppy eats too fast)

CRATE & BEDDING

- ☐ Crate with a movable divider
- ☐ Washable crate pad or blanket
- ☐ Exercise pen (optional)

POTTY TRAINING

- ☐ Enzyme cleaner
- ☐ Potty pads (optional)
- ☐ Waste bags

COLLAR, LEASH & ID

- ☐ Flat collar + ID tag
- ☐ 4–6 ft leash (no retractable)
- ☐ No-pull harness
- ☐ Microchip registered to you

TOYS & CHEWS

- ☐ Teething chew (puppy-safe)
- ☐ KONG Puppy (stuffable, freezable)
- ☐ Puzzle or treat-dispensing toy
- ☐ Fetch & tug toys

GROOMING & HEALTH

- ☐ Nail grinder or clippers
- ☐ Soft brush
- ☐ Dog toothbrush + enzymatic toothpaste
- ☐ Vet wellness exam scheduled (week 1)

Quick tip: Start with the same food the breeder or shelter used and transition to a new brand gradually over 7–10 days. Look for an AAFCO statement confirming the food is "complete and balanced for growth."

The 3-3-3 Rule

What to expect in your puppy's first 3 months

3 Days — Decompress

Your puppy is overwhelmed by a brand-new world. Give them a small, quiet safe space.

- Keep in crate or pen in one calm room
- Let the puppy exit the crate on their own
- No forced interaction or visitors
- Same food, fresh water; reduced appetite is normal

3 Weeks — Learn the Routine

Consistency clicks. The puppy learns when meals and potty breaks happen.

- Set predictable feeding, potty, play & sleep times
- Begin short positive-reinforcement training
- Housetraining starts to stick
- Start gentle handling (paws, ears, mouth)

3 Months — Feel at Home

The puppy treats the home as territory and shows their true personality.

- Reliable housetraining rhythm forms
- Comfortable with family members
- Continue vaccination series & socialization
- Discuss spay/neuter timing with your vet

Remember: The 3-3-3 rule is a widely shared framework used by shelters and rescues — a helpful guide, not a clinical deadline. Every puppy adjusts at their own pace. Let yours build confidence gradually.

Your First Week: Daily Checklist

Tick off one task each day to build good habits from day one

Day	Task	Done
Day 1	Set up crate & safe space; let puppy explore at their own pace	☐
Day 1	Take puppy to potty spot on arrival & after every nap/meal	☐
Day 1	Keep environment quiet; limit visitors & handling	☐
Day 2	Begin a consistent feeding & potty schedule	☐
Day 2	Clean any accident with enzyme cleaner	☐
Day 3	Schedule a wellness vet visit (vaccines & checkup)	☐
Day 3	Begin gentle handling: paws, ears, mouth + treats	☐
Day 4	Start short crate-nap routine (puppies need 18–20 hrs sleep)	☐
Day 5	First brief training session (name, sit, eye contact)	☐
Day 6	Begin safe, positive socialization (new sounds, surfaces, people)	☐
Day 7	Review the week; adjust routine as needed	☐

WHEN TO CALL THE VET IMMEDIATELY

- ☐ Refusal to eat or drink for more than 12 hours
- ☐ Repeated vomiting, or diarrhea lasting more than a day (especially with blood)
- ☐ Lethargy, weakness, or difficulty breathing
- ☐ Straining to urinate/defecate, or no urination

Poison emergency? Call the ASPCA Animal Poison Control Center at **(888) 426-4435** (24/7) if your puppy eats chocolate, xylitol, grapes, rat poison, or human medication.

Full guide: Read the complete first-30-days article with shopping links and photos at thecaringpet.com/blog/new-puppy-essentials-checklist/